

McAfee's Pratim Mukherjee on fighting deepfake AI scams in 2024 and beyond

Pratim Mukherjee
Senior Director of Engineering, McAfee



Jayesh Shinde | jayesh@digit.in

Beyond the famous Obama or Morgan Freeman videos, the world of deepfakes is no longer just science fiction. They are definitely not a laughing matter. With a staggering 10x increase in deepfake incidents detected globally from 2022 to 2023, these AI-generated forgeries are posing a significant threat.

Warren Buffet, arguably the greatest investor of our time, recently mentioned during a shareholder meeting that AI scamming will be the next big growth industry in the world. "As AI continues to grow in popularity, deepfakes will likely become increasingly realistic and frequent. The biggest challenge is continuing to win the cat and mouse game that cybersecurity companies play with the bad actors, to ensure that our AI can beat their AI," according to Pratim Mukherjee, Senior Director of Engineering, McAfee.

In an exclusive interview with Digit, Pratim Mukherjee demystified some of the evolving unknowns surrounding

deepfake AI related scams, how McAfee is trying to fight them, and the need for heightened safety posture for everyone in an increasingly AI-driven world. Edited excerpts follow:

Q Can you elaborate on the specific functionalities of Project Mockingbird? How does it differ from existing deepfake detection solutions?

A McAfee's Deepfake Detector (formerly known as "Project Mockingbird") utilises advanced AI detection models to identify AI-generated audio within videos, helping people understand their digital world and assess the authenticity of content. The functionality of this AI detection technology is far-ranging and will prove invaluable to consumers amidst a rise in AI-generated scams and disinformation: these deepfake audio detection capabilities will put the power of knowing what is real or fake directly into the hands of consumers. This will help consumers avoid 'cheapfake' scams where a cloned celebrity is claiming a new limited-time giveaway, and make sure consumers know instantaneously, when watching a video about a political candidate,

whether it's real or AI-generated. This takes protection in the age of AI to a whole new level, giving users the clarity and confidence to navigate the nuances in this new AI-driven world, to protect their online privacy and identity, and well-being. McAfee's Deepfake Detector is unique in its focus on audio analysis; it uses a combination of AI-powered contextual, behavioural, and categorical detection models to identify whether the audio in a video is likely AI-generated. This provides unmatched protection capabilities to consumers.

Q McAfee has partnered with Intel on AI-powered PCs. How does this partnership specifically address deepfake threats on consumer devices?

A The collaboration between McAfee and Intel addresses a crucial consumer and societal need by helping individuals discern truth from fiction amidst the rise of AI-manipulated deepfake scams. Cybercriminals frequently use AI to alter audio in videos, creating convincing yet deceptive content. McAfee's Deepfake Detector utilises advanced AI detection